



ASTON VILLA FC

DATA-DRIVEN SCOUTING REPORT

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Introduction and outline

TASK INTRODUCTION

The objective of this report is **to identify two areas for sporting improvement** for Aston Villa FC based on data-driven insights. A list of **five targeted players**, with one prioritized, will be proposed in alignment with the club's playing style for each of the two identified profiles. A **detailed analysis** of the strengths and weaknesses of the proposed profiles will be supported by data-driven justifications, and the selection of these players must align with the club's transfer history, playing style, and values.

This report will also showcase the capabilities offered by the data from the **Cube** platform combined with that from the **Transfermarkt** website. Most of the data used will be sourced from these two platforms.

3

Club context

4

Transfer strategy

6

Tactical analysis

8

Performance analysis

11

Transfer targets

19

Executive summary



Club context

FOUNDATION AND IDENTITY

Aston Villa Football Club, founded in 1874, is one of England's oldest and most storied clubs. Established by members of the Villa Cross Wesleyan Chapel, the club's identity is deeply rooted in the community of **Aston, Birmingham**. Villa's philosophy emphasizes passion, unity, and pride, reflecting the **working-class spirit** of its origins. The club's values center around inclusivity and community engagement, fostering a strong bond with supporters. This rich heritage shapes Aston Villa's unique character within English football.

PERFORMANCE AND LEGACY

Aston Villa's glory period spans the late 19th and early 20th centuries, marked by seven First Division titles and seven FA Cup victories. The club's European Cup triumph in 1982 stands as a pinnacle achievement. Since the Premier League's inception in 1992, Villa has **experienced varied fortunes**, including **top-six finishes** and UEFA Champions League qualifications. However, recent decades have seen challenges, including **relegation battles**. Despite these fluctuations, Villa's legacy remains defined by historic successes and a **resilient spirit**.

RECENT HISTORY AND FUTURE ASPIRATIONS

In recent seasons, Aston Villa has experienced significant changes, with new ownership and manager aimed at revitalizing the club. Under **Unai Emery's** leadership, Villa has demonstrated promising improvements, emphasizing **tactical discipline and the development of young talent**. The club's medium-term goals include securing a top-half finish in the Premier League and qualifying for European competitions. In the long term, Aston Villa aims to **reestablish itself as a leading English club**, investing in infrastructure and community initiatives to foster success.



Transfer strategy

Previous seasons

Summer 2022

Adding experience and **quality** to the team, with players having Champions League experience

Selling to **maintain financial stability**

Diego Carlos (CB)
31 000 000 €

Philippe Coutinho (CAM)
20 000 000 €

Boubacar Kamara (CDM)
Free transfer

Carney Chukwuemeka (CM)
18 000 000 €

Matt Targett (LB)
17 500 000 €

Unai Emery's arrival

Winter 2023

Rejuvenating the squad to secure quality over the long term

Beefing up the squad and bringing in some competition

Jhon Durán (ST)
29 500 000 €

Álex Moreno (LB)
13 500 000 €

Danny Ings (ST)
12 000 000 €

Summer 2023

Improving technical ability on all the lines of the pitch

Separating profiles that **don't fit** in with Emery's game plan

Moussa Diaby (RW)
55 000 000 €

Pau Torres (CB)
33 000 000 €

Youri Tielemans (CM)
Free transfer

Cameron Archer (ST)
21 550 000 €

Philippe Coutinho (CAM)
Loan

Winter 2024

Providing versatility and **depth** in Emery's attacking setup

Acquiring young **high-potential talent**

Morgan Rogers (CAM)
9 400 000 €

TRANSFER POLICY

Over the past two seasons, Aston Villa has successfully recruited a blend of **experienced players** and promising **U23 talents** who fit Unai Emery's **playing style**. The Spanish coach is committed to **fostering competition** within the squad to elevate the team's performance. Except for Duran's and Rogers' cases, many of these recruits came from the "Big Five" leagues.



Transfer strategy

Current season

Summer 2024

Amadou Onana (CDM)
59 350 000 €

Ian Maatsen (LB)
44 500 000 €

Jaden Philogene (LW)
16 000 000 €

Moussa Diaby (RW)
60 000 000 €

Douglas Luiz (CM)
51 500 000 €

Winter 2025

Donyell Malen (RW)
25 000 000 €

Andrés García (RB)
7 000 000 €

Marco Asensio (RW)
Loan

Marcus Rashford (LW)
Loan

Axel Disasi (CB)
Loan

Jhon Durán (ST)
77 000 000 €

Jaden Philogene (LW)
23 700 000 €

Diego Carlos (CB)
11 470 000 €

2024-2025 SEASON

The summer 2024 transfer window yielded mixed results. The departures of key players like Moussa Diaby and Douglas Luiz, who sought new opportunities, have left **notable gaps in the squad**. While the club has signed two of the three most expensive players in its history, **Amadou Onana and Ian Maatsen have faced challenges**. Onana has struggled with injuries, and Maatsen has primarily been a rotation player. **Philogene** who was also recruited at the summer did not convince and **was sold only six months after his arrival**.

The winter transfer window also presented its own set of difficulties. The club faced with an **economic offer for Jhon Durán** that cannot be refused and **Diego Carlos' desire to leave**. The issue is that securing permanent deals for top players is challenging during this period, leading Aston Villa to opt for strategic **loan agreements**. The club brought in experienced players like **Marco Asensio, Marcus Rashford, and Axel Disasi** on loan to maintain competitiveness without overcommitting resources. While these loans provide short-term solutions, they also mean that these players are likely to leave at the end of the season. Only Malen and García has been bought permanently.

Indeed, these special transfer windows have reduced the Villans' performances this season, as we will see later. Looking ahead, Aston Villa will need to **reassess their squad** in the upcoming summer window. They will have to decide whether to pursue permanent deals for their loan players or explore new recruitment options to fill potential vacancies.



Tactical analysis

Game plan out of possession

PERFORMANCE ANALYSIS USING DATA

To effectively use data in practice to assess a team's performance quality, it's crucial to first understand the theoretical **principles and strategies** the coach aims to implement during the game. This theoretical foundation serves as the framework for defining the **relevant Key Performance Indicators (KPIs)** tracked by Cube. By aligning these KPIs with the game plan, we can accurately measure how well the team executes the coach's intentions. This approach ensures that the data analysis is meaningful and directly tied to the **team's objectives**, allowing for more insightful evaluations and targeted improvements.

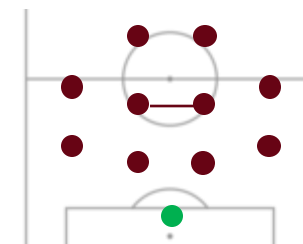


KPIs out of possession

Aggression
Ground duels
High press

AGGRESSIVE MID-BLOCK

Unai Emery's team employs a **compact** and **aggressive** defensive mid-block, typically in a 4-4-2 or 4-4-1-1 formation, depending on the opponent. This setup is designed to **minimize space between the lines** and **force the opposition to play backwards** or into less threatening areas. The **double pivot** in midfield plays a crucial role in this defensive structure. The goalkeeper is responsible for covering runs in behind the defensive line. This defensive also sets the stage for Aston Villa's quick transitions into attack.



HIGH PRESS

Emery aims at winning the ball back quickly and **launching swift counter-attacks**. The high press is supported by the robust double pivot in midfield, which provides defensive stability. While one of the pivot players may push higher up the field to apply pressure, the other remains in a more defensive position to provide cover and maintain the team's shape. This dynamic allows Aston Villa to **press aggressively** without leaving significant gaps in midfield.



Tactical analysis

Game plan in possession



KPIs in possession

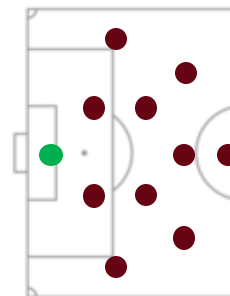
- Central possession
- Central entry
- Counter-attack rate
- Direct play
- Finishing

INTENSE VERTICAL PLAY

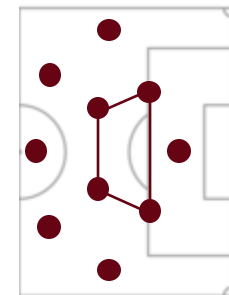
Emery's team is adept at **counter-attacking** and creating goal-scoring opportunities through quick transitional attacks. When recovering the ball, his team focuses on attacking with **central advantages**, usually meaning multiple **players moving inside from wide**. Many players are involved centrally to support these attacks, often using combinations and **fast through-balls** to catch the opposition off guard and create goal-scoring opportunities.

HIGH BUILD-UP TRANSITION

When sustaining the possession, Emery's team usually sets up in an **4-2-3-1** (or sometimes 4-4-2) formation during low build-up phases. This structure transitions to a **3-4-2-1** during high build-up phases to emphasize **central play and numerical advantages**. Using a **box of four** with a double pivot and two attacking midfielders in the half-spaces, the team tries to **exploit spaces** between the center-backs and fullbacks and utilizing fast **through-balls** to catch the opposition off guard.



Low build-up



High build-up



Performance analysis

Performance review

2022-2023

2023-2024

2024-2025

DEFENDING

Aggression

54

49

44

Ground duels

35

4

25

High press

55

18

34

xGA per match ¹

1.43

1.57

1.65

POSS

Central possession

63

75

79

ATTACKING

Central entry

53

68

68

Counter-attack rate

42

82

24

Direct play

46

75

39

Finishing

39

66

32

xG per match ¹

1.29

1.78

1.51

PERFORMANCE QUANTIFICATION

Quantifying performance in the domestic league provides a more **consistent measure** than in cups, as the level of competition remains relatively stable. The performance review should avoid relying on rankings or cup stage achievements, as football's unpredictable nature can lead to overperformance or underperformance. Instead, basing the review on **consistent data** offers a **more reliable assessment**.

2024-2025 SEASON

Defensively, there has been a **noticeable decline in performance** over Emery's years. Following Aston Villa's strongest defensive season (2022-2023) under his management, key performance indicators have decreased, resulting in increasing expected goals against per match.

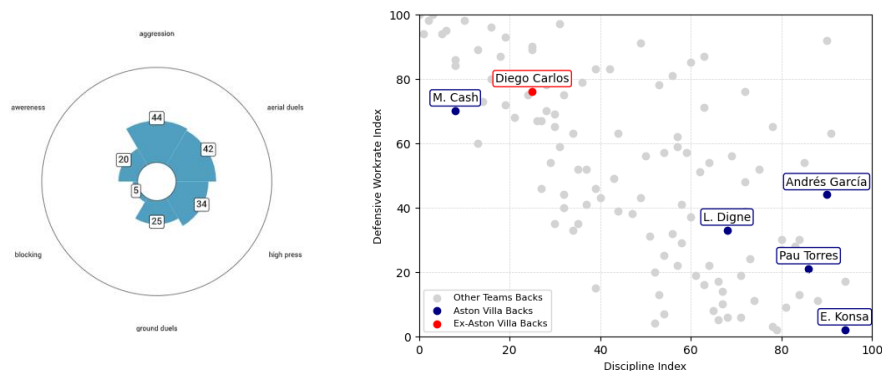
Offensively, the 2023-2024 season was the most impressive under Emery's orders, characterized by a **high counter-attack rate, direct play, and strong finishing**. This resulted in particularly high expected goals per match that **have been lost this season**, probably linked in part to the departure of Moussa Diaby during summer 2024.



Performance analysis

Identification of weaknesses

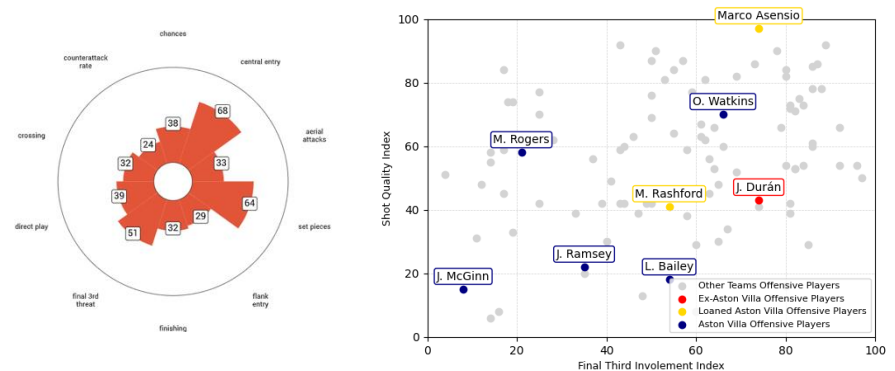
SHAKY BACKLINE



This season, Aston Villa's squad not only falls short on Emery's KPIs but also **rank below the average Premier League team in all defensive metrics** tracked by Cube. This highlights a critical issue that must be addressed next summer. Failure to do so could jeopardize the team's objectives for next season, as achieving a top ranking will be challenging with the **13th best expected defense**.

The most glaring example of this defensive fragility is the back line. Apart from Matty Cash, who is frequently injured, and Diego Carlos, who left the club during the winter, **Aston Villa's backs commit too many fouls and have struggled to make significant defensive contributions**. It is obvious that this situation negatively impacts the team's overall performance and dynamics.

LACK OF FINISHERS



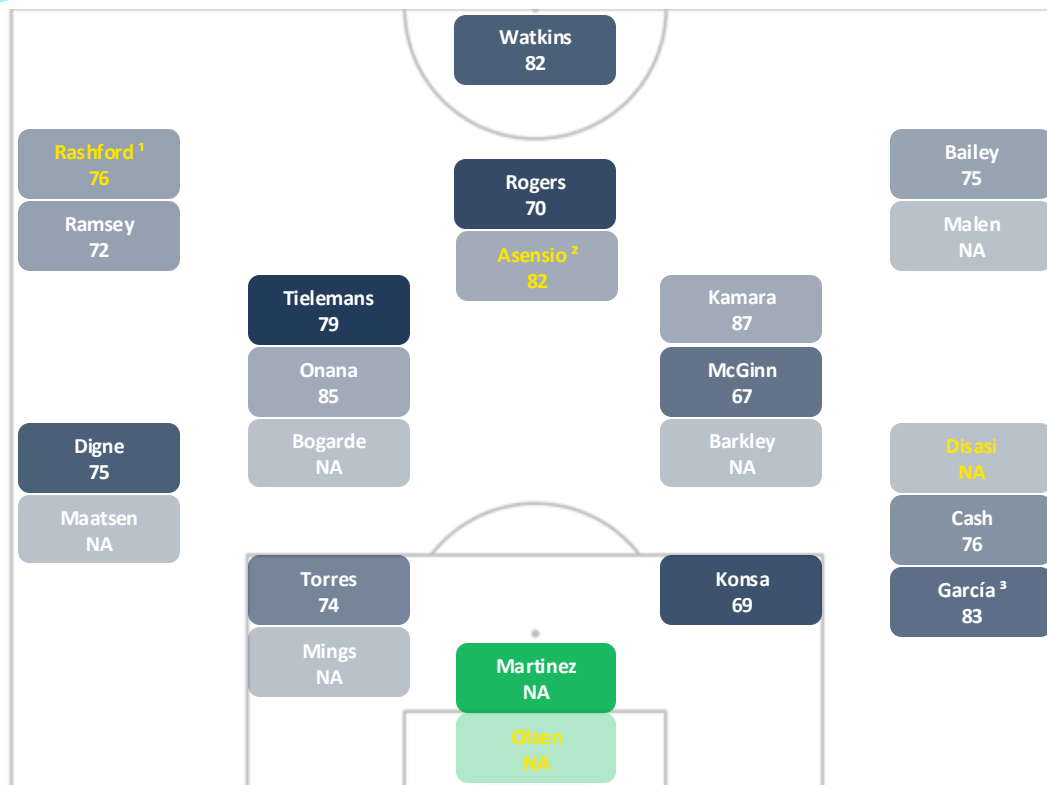
Regarding attacking metrics, Aston Villa's performance is also concerning. While the team is performant in central entries, set-pieces and is average in creating threats in the final third, they **fall below the league average in other key offensive metrics** tracked by Cube, **especially counter-attack rate and direct play**. This likely contributes to their ranking as the **14th best expected attack**.

Analyzing their offensive players, it's clear that **aside from Watkins, no player belonging to Aston Villa significantly contributes to both final third involvement and quality shooting**. Only loaned players like Asensio and partially Rashford have shown this capability. The team shows a real lack of another strong finisher to bolster their attacking prowess.



Performance analysis

Squad overview



NB: The more a player has played, the opaquer the box in which he is indicated.

The players in yellow are those whose contract/loan expires at the end of the 2024-2025 season.

Some player performance index were calculated by including matches at: ¹ Manchester United (ENG 1)

² Paris Saint-Germain (FRA 1)

³ Levante (SPA 2)



FOOTBALL
FORUM
HUNGARY

AREAS TO BE STRENGTHENED

Regarding the goalkeeper position, Martinez remains a top-tier keeper, while Olsen's contract will expire at the end of the season. Therefore, **reinforcement will be necessary to secure a backup goalkeeper.**

For the defensive line, Disasi's departure in the summer, as he was on loan, and Kinsa's poor performances, indicated by his low-performance index and defensive fragility, highlight **a critical need for a right center back**, both in terms of quality and quantity.

In the central midfield, Asensio's departure should be offset by Rogers' emergence and the ability of Tielemans, McGinn, and Ramsey to cover the attacking midfielder position following other player returns from injury.

On the wings, Bailey and Malen can play on both sides. Ramsey is also interesting because he is the only 'creative' winger of the squad. However, there will be **a qualitative and quantitative gap if Rashford's buy option is not exercised.**

Up front, although Watkins performs exceptionally well, **the team lacks a suitable backup striker.**





Transfer targets

Targeted profiles

PROACTIVE CENTER BACK

Addressing the team's defensive inefficiencies, particularly Konsa's poor performances and the absence of a right center back, highlights a critical need for reinforcement at this position. The aim of this transfer will be to inject **dynamism and aggression into the back line**, while also facilitating **quick and vertical play** upon ball recovery, thereby re-establishing Emery's tactical DNA.



MUST HAVE

- Right-footed
- Def. workrate > 60
- Verticality > 50
- Minutes played > 50%



SHOULD HAVE

- Can also play in another position during high build-up phases
- Under 23
- Big Five player and/or European experience

EFFICIENT WINGER

Regarding the team's shortcomings in finishing and the absence of a third direct winger, it is crucial to reinforce this position. The objective of this transfer will be to acquire a winger capable of executing **fast transitional attacks**, aligning with Emery's playing style, and possessing **strong finishing abilities** to fulfill Aston Villa's needs up front. A player with the ability to play on both wings would give more options.



MUST HAVE

- Direct winger
- Final 3rd inv. > 70
- Shot quality > 70
- Minutes played > 50%



SHOULD HAVE

- Can play on both wings
- Under 23
- Big Five player and/or European experience



Transfer targets

Rashford's buy option

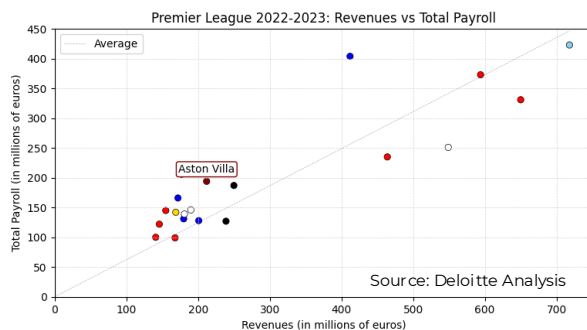


Rashford
Winger

FINANCIAL CONSIDERATIONS

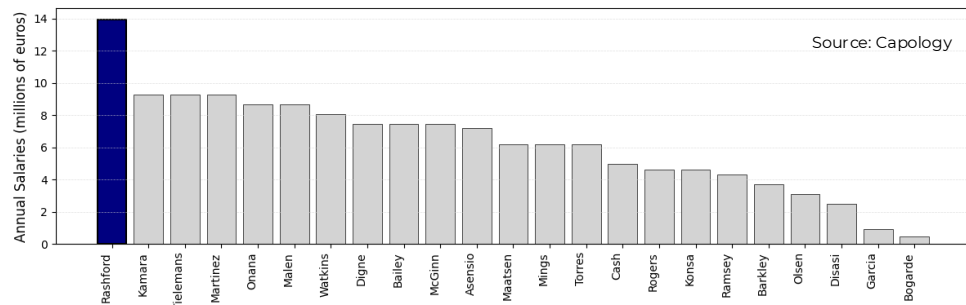
Given that Marcus Rashford's profile aligns with Aston Villa's needs on the wing if he would regain his best form, and considering the club can exercise the buy option in his loan contract next summer, **Rashford is a potential target.** However, other financial considerations must be carefully evaluated to ensure the club's overall financial health.

SALARY CAP TO MONITOR



In the club financial statements of Premier League 2022-2023 season, salary expenses typically accounted for 62% of club revenues. For Aston Villa, this figure stood at **92% of its revenues**. It is crucial to consider reducing this percentage to ensure the club's financial health and **avoid debt accumulation**.

RISK TOO GREAT?

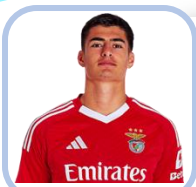


Marcus Rashford is the **highest-paid player at Aston Villa**, but his performances have yet to justify this status. Although Manchester United still covers 30% of his salary, this arrangement will end if the buy option is exercised. If Rashford's performances do not meet expectations, it could prompt his top-performing teammates to negotiate similar salaries, potentially **leading the club into a financial spiral**. The extent of this risk must be carefully evaluated before taking any decision.



Transfer targets

Proactive center back - shortlist



António Silva



Age
21

Foot
Right

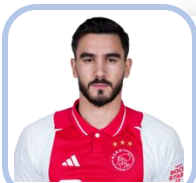
2nd position
NA

Minutes
785

Def. Work.
66

Vert.
73

38 M€



Josip Šutalo



Age
25

Foot
Right

2nd position
NA

Minutes
1933

Def. Work.
60

Vert.
65

22 M€



Ryan Flamingo



Age
22

Foot
Right

2nd position
Def. Mid.

Minutes
2420

Def. Work.
69

Vert.
79

16 M€



Mees Hilgers



Age
23

Foot
Right

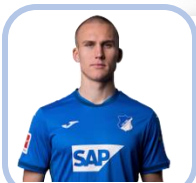
2nd position
NA

Minutes
1421

Def. Work.
75

Vert.
59

7 M€



Leo Østigård



Age
25

Foot
Right

2nd position
NA

Minutes
484

Def. Work.
95

Vert.
57

7 M€



Transfer targets

Ryan Flamingo analysis



Ryan Flamingo



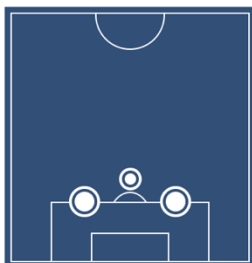
22 years old

1,87 m

75 kg

Right-footed

Main position:
Centre-Back
Other position:
Defensive Midfield



2014



Almere City FC

Youth academy and first appearances with U21s. Focus on youth development and technical skills.

2021



US Sassuolo

First experience abroad, gaining Serie A exposure. Attacking and possession-based football.

2022



Vitesse Arnhem

Eredivisie debut, versatile performances in defense and midfield. High-pressing and counter-attacking style.

2023



FC Utrecht

Key defensive role on loan, consistent league contributions. Balanced, possession-oriented approach.

2024



PSV Eindhoven

First Champions League appearances. Dynamic, attacking football with a focus on youth integration.

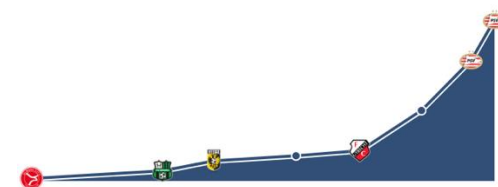
Eredivisie 24/25
Statistics

Appearances	26	Yellow Cards	2
Goals	0	Second Yellows	0
Assists	2	Red cards	0



Current Market Value :
€16.00m

Highest market value:
€16.00m
Dec 17, 2024





Transfer targets

Ryan Flamingo analysis



Ryan Flamingo



22 years old

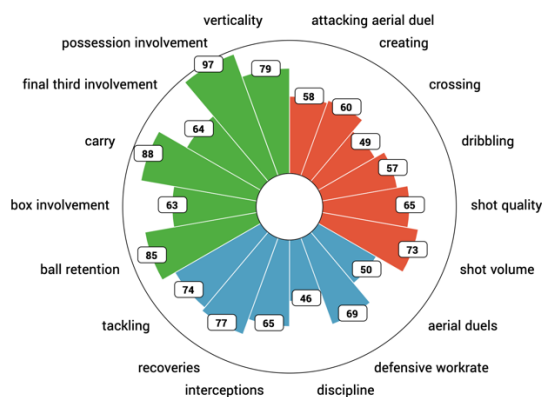
1,87 m

75 kg

Right-footed

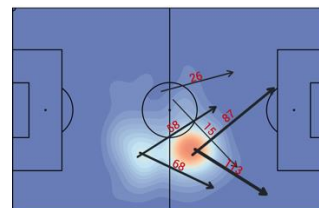
STYLE OVERVIEW

Ryan Flamingo is a ball-playing center back. As he showed during the Champions League, he is **very strong in defense** and will fit perfectly into Emery's Aston Villa due to his **above-average defensive workrate**. Additionally, he possesses **great abilities to play vertically** and demonstrates exceptional skills with the ball, particularly in carrying, ball retention, and possession involvement.



ADAPTABILITY AND VERTICALITY

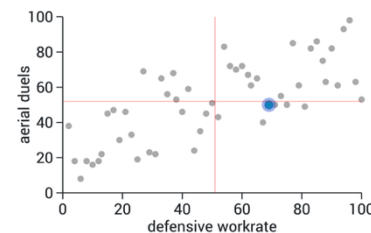
Flamingo is a highly versatile player who can play in **several positions**. His adaptability will be beneficial in Emery's system, especially during high build-up phases.



He can initiate progressive passes **from various areas** of the field, and **towards the opponent's goal**. This aligns perfectly with Aston Villa's desire to implement a direct style of play.

POTENTIAL IMPROVEMENT IN THE AIR

Although he does not fall significantly below average in any defensive aspect, he still has room for improvement in **aerial duels**. His weight relative to his 1m87 height indicates a **need to strengthen his physique** to meet the athletic demands of the Premier League.





Transfer targets

Efficient winger - shortlist



Johan Bakayoko



Age
21

Foot
Left

Position(s)
RW

Minutes
1456

Fin. 3rd Inv. Finishing
99 71

35 M€



Francisco Trincão



Age
25

Foot
Left

Position(s)
RW, LW, AM

Minutes
2430

Fin. 3rd Inv. Finishing
76 74

27 M€



Dan Ndoye



Age
24

Foot
Right

Position(s)
RW, LW

Minutes
1801

Fin. 3rd Inv. Finishing
87 80

25 M€



Abde Ezzalzouli



Age
23

Foot
Right

Position(s)
LW, RW

Minutes
1737

Fin. 3rd Inv. Finishing
82 81

12 M€



Mika Godts



Age
19

Foot
Right

Position(s)
LW, RW, AM

Minutes
1277

Fin. 3rd Inv. Finishing
85 76

10 M€



Transfer targets

Dan Ndoye analysis



Dan Ndoye



24 years old

1,84 m

79 kg

Right-footed

Main position:
Right Winger
Other position:
Right Midfield
Left Winger



2014



FC Lausanne-Sport

Youth academy, rapid progression through U18s. Focus on youth development and technical skills.

2020



OGC Nice

Struggling for consistency. Balanced approach, combining young and experienced players.

2021



FC Basel

Playing a crucial role. Structured, possession-based system under Patrick Rahmen.

2023



Bologna FC

Key forward under Motta. Dynamic vision and breaking down defenses in a tactically flexible team.

Serie A 24/25
Statistics

Appearances	25	Yellow Cards	2
Goals	7	Second Yellows	0
Assists	3	Red cards	0



Current Market Value :
€25.00m

Highest market value:
€25.00m
Dec 18, 2024





Transfer targets

Dan Ndoye analysis



Dan Ndoye



24 years old

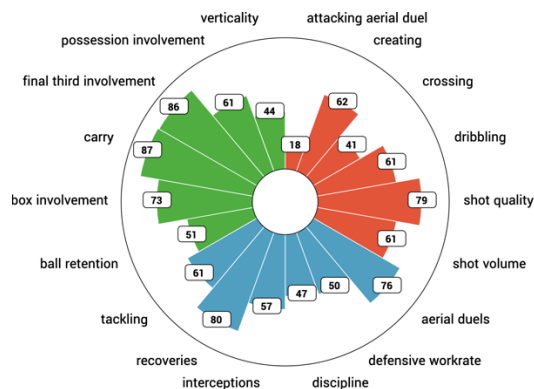
1,84 m

79 kg

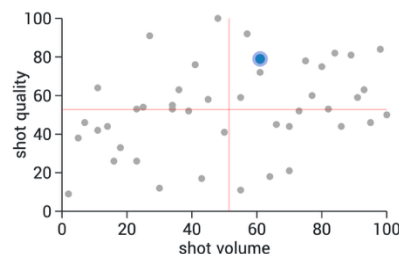
Right-footed

STYLE OVERVIEW

Dan Ndoye is a versatile direct winger who can play on both flanks and occasionally as a second striker for his national team. He excels in **carrying the ball and contributing in the final third**. Additionally, his **above-average shooting** ability makes him a decisive attacker and will help Aston Villa regain some offensive dynamism. His dribbling ability will also be valuable during the high build-up phase.



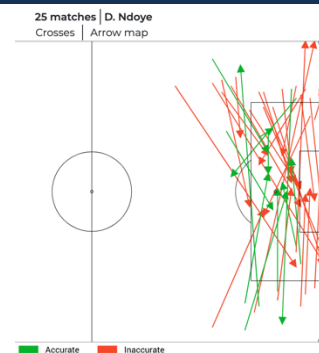
CLINICAL FINISHER



Dan Ndoye is a skilled finisher with an above-average ability to generate shots. His **high conversion rate** will allow Aston Villa to not rely solely on Ollie Watkins and to aspire to become a strong attacking force in the league once again.

POTENTIAL IMPROVEMENT ON CROSSES

However, Ndoye is lacking in his crossing ability. **His crosses are often inaccurate or too long**, as shown on the plot on the right. This is a crucial area for improvement for a winger of his profile. By working on this aspect, he can become a more decisive player and help his team winning more games.





Executive summary



Club strategy

Become a dominant English club again by including promising young players

Game plan

Aggressive mid-block and vertical play through high density in the axis



1

Keep trusting
coaches over
the long term



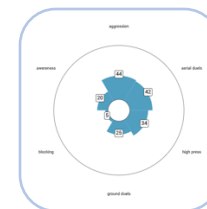
Financial context

Keep transfer costs and payroll from exploding

DATA-DRIVEN SCOUTING REPORT

Areas for improvement

Strengthening of the
defensive line and
acquisition of a finisher



2

Be prepared
for key player
departures



Ryan Flamingo

Versatile ball-playing center back to
bring his defensive workrate and
his ability to find vertical passes



Dan Ndoye

Adaptable direct winger to
bring his creativity in the final
third and his scoring abilities

3

Rely on
high-potential
young players





**FOOTBALL
FORUM**
HUNGARY